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Ouroboros RPG: Quickstart Guide v4.3

A Tabletop Roleplaying Game of Reincarnation and Spiritual Evolution

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Welcome to the Eternal Journey

In Ouroboros, you don't just play a character — you play a **soul**. An immortal consciousness journeying through human history, living many lives, learning through experience, and evolving across millennia.

Why Reincarnation?

Most RPGs end when your character dies. In Ouroboros, death is a transition. Your soul continues, and so does your story.

Continuity across campaigns: Play wildly different characters — a Roman gladiator, a Tang Dynasty poet, a Victorian detective, a cyberpunk hacker — while maintaining the same soul's journey. XP carries forward. Awakened skills make learning faster. Your choices echo across centuries.

Relationships that persist: The party isn't just adventurers who met at a tavern. You're a soul group that has found each other across lifetimes. That rival? You were brothers once. That mentor? She was your student three lives ago. That romance? It's been burning for a thousand years.

Meaningful consequences: Win a war in medieval France, and your next incarnation might be born on the losing side — experiencing what you inflicted. The universe doesn't punish; it teaches.

Narrative possibilities: Flashbacks to past lives. Recovered memories. Ghosts of people you knew. Prophecies from centuries ago. Meeting the reincarnation of a friend who died. Mysteries spanning millennia.

Soul Memory

Normal souls don't explicitly remember past lives. Instead, they experience: - Vague feelings of familiarity - Déjà vu with places or people - Unexplained fears or attractions - Dreams that might be memories - Instant recognition of soul-family

With Initiation, souls slowly learn to access memories.

Soul Groups

Soul groups incarnate **at the same time**. The GM decides proximity:

Spread Apart: Different continents, cultures, even opposing sides. Historical events bring the group together. Works for war, world-spanning adventure, cross-cultural stories.

Close Together: Same city, court, or community. Different roles within that setting. Works for intrigue, local drama, tight-knit stories.

Mixed: Some near, some far. Core group starts together, others join through events. Works for most campaigns.

Key principles: same TIME, variable PLACE, will INTERACT.

Campaign Styles

Intrigue, war, adventure, horror, mystery, romance, tragedy, epic, slice of life — mix and match freely.

How Stories End

Every lifetime ends. Some examples: glorious death, heroic sacrifice, peaceful old age, meeting a fallen friend's reincarnation, tragedy, or simply continuing through the doorway of death.

The Card System

Setup

- **Player Deck**: Shared by all players
- **GM Deck**: For NPCs
- **Hand Size**: Each player holds cards equal to Willpower

Card Values

Card	Value
Ace - 10	Face value
Jack	+5 overlay (match color)
Queen	2nd strike (card value) / intercept for ally
King	Cancel active defense / cancel incoming attack
Joker	1-10 wildcard (Black ♠♣, Red ♥♦)

The Golden Rule

For skills, lower is better. For combat, higher is better. > **Realistic teach time:** Allow 15 minutes to explain the system to new players — 5 if everyone is already a card-game player. The dual-direction rule (low for skills, high for combat) is the one concept that needs the most time. Use the side-by-side examples in the Quick Reference table at the end of this document.

Blind Draws

Always available. Face cards drawn blindly count as value **5** (neutral midpoint — not discarded, not redrawn). Jokers declare value and suit.

GM Card Use

Most NPCs: Blind draw (face card = 5). Jokers return to deck after resolving. **Important NPCs**: GM maintains a hand.

Character Basics

The Eight Attributes

Element	Physical	Mental
Earth ♠	Constitution	Discipline
Water ♥	Strength	Wisdom
Air ♦	Dexterity	Empathy
Fire ♣	Reflexes	Intelligence

Costs

Type	Formula
Attributes	New Level × 5 XP
Skills	Basic 5 / Practiced 10 / Deep 15 XP

All 8 attributes begin at Level 1 for free. Spend XP only to raise above Level 1.

The Four Circles

Circle	Formula
Earth	(Constitution + Discipline) ÷ 2
Water	(Strength + Wisdom) ÷ 2
Air	(Dexterity + Empathy) ÷ 2
Fire	(Reflexes + Intelligence) ÷ 2

Derived Values

Willpower = floor((Earth + Water + Air + Fire) ÷ 4), minimum 2 = **Hand Size**

HP = (Earth × 4) + (Water × 3) + (Air × 2) + (Fire × 1) + 10

Six Innate Abilities

Ability	Formula
Athletics	(Earth + Water) ÷ 2
Perception	(Earth + Fire) ÷ 2
Influence	(Water + Air) ÷ 2
Intuition	(Water + Fire) ÷ 2
Composure	(Earth + Air) ÷ 2
Insight	(Air + Fire) ÷ 2

Four Saving Throws

Save	Formula	Resists
Fortitude	(E + W + F) ÷ 3	Poison, disease
Reflex	(W + A + F) ÷ 3	Explosions, traps
Resolve	(E + A + F) ÷ 3	Mind control, fear
Nerve	(E + W + A) ÷ 3	Manipulation, despair

Severity	TN
Minor	5
Moderate	2
Serious	−1
Severe	−4

Check: Card − Save ≤ TN

There is **no auto-success tier** for saves. Apply the appropriate TN based on effect severity.

Skills

Check: Card − Circle − Resonance ≤ TN (lower is better)

Difficulty	TN
Trivial	Auto
Easy	5
Moderate	2
Hard	−1
Extreme	−4
Legendary	−7
Mythic	−10
Divine	−13
Cosmic	−16

Combat

Formula

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Attack Total = Card + Attribute + Skill + Weapon + Bonuses
Defense Total = Card + Attribute + Skill + Armor + Bonuses
Damage = Attack - Defense
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Higher is better. **+X attack** means any offensive bonus. **Damage** is only the result.

Passive Defense

Reflexes + Armor (no card, no skill)

Combat Sequence

1. **Initiative**: Card + Fire + Air circles (highest first)
2. **Assignment**: 2 cards face-down (Upward = Defense, Downward = Attack)
3. **Actions**: Two card actions + one movement + free interactions
4. **Resolution**: Phase 1 high→low, Phase 2 low→high. Targets may react with defense.

Face Cards

Card	Effect
Jack	+5 to total (match color)
Queen	Attack: second strike at card value only vs a 2nd target; Defense: intercept an attack on an adjacent ally

Card	Effect
King	Attack: cancel target's active defense; Defense: cancel the incoming attack entirely

Opposed Checks

Both play cards. Card − Circle − Resonance. **Lowest wins.** Ties = status quo.

Positioning

Range	Meaning
Engaged	In melee
Near	Same zone
Far	Different zone

Cover	Bonus
Light	+1
Half	+3
Heavy	+5
Fortified	+10

Jobs

Powers trigger on **numbered cards** of your job's suit (EVEN or ODD). Face cards don't trigger powers.

Power Scaling: Instant/attack powers use Circle for magnitude. Zone/buff powers use Circle for duration with fixed magnitude.

Job Access: Circle threshold opens access to a tier; XP per level buys levels within it (Tier 1 = 5 XP, Tier 2 = 8 XP). All tiers max out at 4 levels. Jobs do **not** unlock automatically from circles alone. The **core game** uses Tier 1 (relevant circle ≥ 2) and cross-suit Tier 2 (Level 2 in both parent Tier 1 jobs). Same-suit Tier 2, Tier 3, and Tier 4 are expansion content (`_expansion/Jobs_Tier3_Tier4.md`).

♠ WARRIOR

Lvl	EVEN (Attack)	ODD (Defense)
1	**Precision Strike**: +Earth attack	**Defensive Stance**: +Earth defense; counter-attack if missed

Lvl	EVEN (Attack)	ODD (Defense)
2	**Power Attack**: +Earth×2 attack, -2 attack	**Shield Wall**: +Earth defense; allies Near gain half

♥ HEALER

Lvl	EVEN	ODD
1	**Healing Touch**: Heal Water×2 HP	**Protection**: +3 defense for Water rounds
2	**Mass Heal**: Allies Near heal Water HP	**Sanctuary**: Zone +3 defense for Water rounds

♦ ROGUE

Lvl	EVEN	ODD
1	**Precision**: +Air×2 attack vs unaware, ignore armor	**Dodge**: +Air defense, disengage free
2	**Exploit Weakness**: +Air×2 attack if weakness known	**Vanish**: Invisible until you attack

♣ MAGE

Lvl	EVEN (Elemental)	ODD (Probability)
1	**Elemental Negotiation**: Enhance an existing elemental effect in the environment by Fire value (requires an elemental source: fire, running water, storm, etc.)	**Deck Sight**: Look at top Fire cards of any deck, rearrange in any order
2	**Elemental Burst**: Work with elementals to intensify an existing effect. Requires elemental source AND preparation OR alchemical component. Deals Fire×2 to all in area.	**Probability Shift**: Force one character (ally or enemy) to discard their current card assignment and blind draw replacements

Mage Casting Note: Non-Initiates cannot create elemental effects from nothing. They enhance, negotiate, and direct existing elemental activity. Probability powers (card manipulation) work without any elemental source—fate is always present.

Mage Casting

Casting can look like: normal actions, prayer, dance, yelling instructions, small gestures, craft work. Magic looks like coincidence to observers.

Equipment

Weapons

Type	Attack Bonus
Light	+1
Medium	+2
Heavy	+3

Armor

Type	Defense
Light	+1
Medium	+2
Heavy	+3

Mage Equipment

Alchemical compounds, elemental arrows, focus items, prepared materials.

Card Flow

- **Hand Size**: Always = Willpower
- **Blind Draw**: Always available — assign from top of deck without looking instead of from hand
- **In combat**: draw back to Hand Size **immediately** after assigning cards (not at end of round)
- **Full Rest**: Discard all, draw fresh hand equal to Hand Size
- **Short Rest**: Discard one card, draw one replacement
- **Meditation**: Retain one card through a full rest OR discard one extra during rest
- **Deck Empty**: Immediately reshuffle graveyard and continue drawing

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Awakening

Soul Resonances (Martial, Social, Mystical, Scholarly, Craft, Survival) fully transfer between lives.

Re-buying: Attributes, circles, jobs, and learned skills reset each life, then re-buy at **half XP by default** once awakened (GM-adjustable 25–75%).

Initiation

Path beyond mortal limits. Requires Willpower 4+ and spiritual trials. Allows exceeding maximums, Tier 4 powers, persistent memories, direct elemental manifestation.

Between Lives

Carries forward: Soul Resonances, awakening discounts, fate, and soul relationships.

Resets: Attributes, circles, jobs, learned skills, equipment, and physical form/gender/culture. Previously developed levels re-buy at half XP by default once the relevant circle threshold is reached.

NPC Stats

Type	Attr	Skill	Notes
Commoner	1	+0	Harmless
Guard	1-2	+0	Basic training
Soldier	2	+1	Professional
Veteran	2-3	+1	Experienced
Elite	3	+2	Dangerous alone
Champion	3-4	+2	Major threat
Master	4	+3	Arc villain
Legendary	4-5	+3	Campaign nemesis
Initiated	5+	+3-4	Testing or Fallen Master

Quick Reference

Check Type	Formula
Skills	Card − Circle − Resonance ≤ TN (low wins)
Combat	Card + Attr + Skill + Equipment (high wins)
Opposed	Both play, lowest wins
Costs	Attributes: Level×5 XP · Skills: Basic 5 / Practiced 10 / Deep 15 XP

Next Steps

See the **Demo Adventure** for pre-generated characters and an introductory three-session scenario.

Your First Session as GM

Before Session 1

Elemental Sources for Mage Players: If anyone is playing a Mage, review your opening scenes and confirm at least two elemental sources are present in each location. A dungeon without fire or flowing water is frustrating for an Elemental Negotiation Mage. One torch, one puddle — that's all it takes. Probability Mages don't need this.

The First Death: Expect at least one character to die in your first campaign. When it happens: - Take a brief break to acknowledge the moment - Let the player narrate their death scene - Note which Soul Resonances fully transfer and which learned levels can be re-bought at the awakened discount in the next life - Work with the player to design the new incarnation immediately — don't end the session - Introduce the reincarnated soul within 1-2 scenes using one of the transitions in Chapter 7

Hand Size 2 Reminder: Every starting character's Hand Size is 2, minimum. Even if Willpower calculates to 1, the character holds 2 cards. Write "2" on the sheet, not the raw calculation.

Running Smooth Combat

Use an Initiative Tracker: Write initiative numbers on a piece of paper or a whiteboard. When characters change initiative (unusual but possible), update it immediately. The two-phase system (Phase 1: high→low, Phase 2: low→high) confuses new players more than anything else — pointing at the tracker as you call each action prevents "wait, is this Phase 1 or Phase 2?" every round.

Call out the Phase: Say "Phase 1" loudly as it begins and "Phase 2" loudly when it begins. This simple narration eliminates 90% of phase confusion.

The Dual-Direction Rule in Practice

When a player looks uncertain about whether to aim high or low: ask them "are you trying to accomplish something, or are you trying to hurt someone?" - Accomplish something → skill check → lower card result is better - Hurt someone → combat → higher total is better

This is the whole system. *The eternal journey awaits. What will your soul learn this time?*